

Warehouse Operations Manual

Owning area: Deliveries

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Applies to: IronStore fulfilment centres and approved third-party logistics sites in Europe

1. Purpose and Overview

This manual defines the minimum operating standards for receiving, storing, picking, packing, and dispatching IronStore customer orders. It is intended to support safe, accurate, and traceable warehouse operations across all product categories, including electronics, home essentials, clothing, outdoor equipment, beauty products, and other consumer goods.

The procedures apply alongside local legal requirements, site instructions, carrier rules, and product-specific controls. Where a local requirement is stricter than this manual, the stricter requirement applies. Deviations must be recorded in the **Atlas Warehouse Management System (WMS)** and approved by the relevant Operations Manager.

2. Scope

This manual covers:

- Supplier and inter-site inbound deliveries.
- Goods receiving, inspection, labelling, and putaway.
- Inventory control, cycle counting, and location management.
- Customer order picking, packing, and dispatch.
- Returns, damaged stock, shortages, and delivery exceptions.
- Warehouse safety, security, and operational reporting.

It does not replace:

- Dangerous goods procedures under **HSE-PRO-014**.
- Transport planning and carrier procurement rules under **DEL-TMS-002**.
- Product compliance, recall, or restricted-goods procedures.
- Site-specific emergency plans and risk assessments.

3. Policy Statement

IronStore warehouses must process stock and orders accurately, safely, and within the service levels agreed with the Deliveries function. Every stock movement must be recorded electronically, and every dispatch must be traceable to an order, parcel, carrier, and operator or system event.

The following principles apply:

- Do not move unscanned stock except during an approved emergency process.
- Do not ship an order with an unresolved quantity, address, or product exception.
- Keep customer data visible only to staff who require it for their role.
- Use the approved packaging format for each product class.
- Escalate safety, compliance, and security concerns immediately.

4. Operating Procedures

4.1 Inbound Delivery Planning

Inbound appointments are created in **Mercury TMS** at least 24 hours before the planned arrival, except for approved urgent deliveries. The booking must include:

- Supplier or origin site.
- Purchase order or transfer order number.
- Pallet, carton, and expected unit quantities.
- Product type and any handling restrictions.
- Carrier, vehicle registration, and estimated arrival time.

The Inbound Team checks the appointment against the purchase order before unloading. Unscheduled vehicles may be held in the designated waiting area and must not unload without approval from the Inbound Supervisor.

The gatehouse or receiving desk records arrival and departure times. Drivers must follow site traffic controls, wear required personal protective equipment (PPE), and remain in the designated area unless escorted.

4.2 Unloading and Receiving

Before unloading, the receiving operator checks:

- Vehicle condition and signs of water, pest, or security damage.
- Seal number, where applicable.
- Pallet stability and visible carton damage.
- Quantity of handling units against the delivery note.

Goods are unloaded only at the assigned bay. A second operator verifies the count for deliveries exceeding 20 pallets or 500 units.

The operator scans the purchase order or transfer order into Atlas WMS and records received quantities by SKU, batch, serial number, and expiry date where required. System receipt is completed on the same working day.

Shortages, overages, substitutions, and unlisted SKUs are placed in the **Inbound Hold** location. The Inbound Supervisor contacts Procurement or the sending site within four working hours. Stock may not be released for sale

until the discrepancy is resolved or formally approved.

4.3 Inspection and Product Controls

A sample inspection is performed on each inbound delivery. The standard sample is:

- Five cartons for deliveries of up to 100 cartons.
- Ten cartons for deliveries over 100 cartons.
- The full delivery where damage or repeated quality issues are identified.

Operators check packaging, labels, product identity, accessories, and visible defects. Electronics with serial numbers must be scanned individually. Beauty products, food-contact items, and other dated goods must meet the minimum remaining shelf-life specified in the purchase order.

Damaged or suspect stock is labelled **QUARANTINE – DO NOT SHIP**, moved to the secure quarantine area, and photographed in Atlas WMS. The Quality Lead decides whether stock is released, reworked, returned, or scrapped. Staff must not repair, repackage, or relabel goods without documented approval.

4.4 Putaway and Storage

Atlas WMS generates the putaway task based on product dimensions, turnover, handling restrictions, and location capacity. Operators must scan both the product and destination location before placing stock.

Storage rules include:

- Heavy items below shoulder height.
- Fragile items in protected shelving or designated cages.
- High-value electronics in access-controlled locations.
- Aerosols, liquids, batteries, and other controlled products in approved areas.
- Clothing and textiles kept dry and protected from contamination.
- Expiry-controlled stock managed using FEFO: first expiry, first out.

A location must not exceed its weight, volume, or pallet-height limit. Empty locations are kept clear, labelled, and available in Atlas WMS. Any unlabelled or inaccessible location is reported to the Inventory Controller.

4.5 Inventory Accuracy

All stock adjustments require a reason code and electronic approval. The following approval levels apply:

- Up to €50 cost value: Inventory Controller.
- €50.01–€500: Warehouse Operations Manager.
- Above €500, repeated variance, or suspected theft: Head of Deliveries and Loss Prevention.

Cycle counts are completed daily according to the Atlas WMS count queue. A location is recounted when the first count differs from the system by more than:

- One unit for serialized products.
- Two units or 2%, whichever is greater, for standard products.
- One case for case-managed inventory.

The counter must not edit the expected quantity before completing the recount. Variances are investigated using receiving records, pick scans, replenishment tasks, and dispatch confirmations.

4.6 Picking

Customer orders are released to the warehouse through Atlas WMS according to the cut-off schedule published by Planning. The default same-day release cut-off is 14:00 local time, although site-specific cut-offs may differ.

Picking operators must:

1. Scan the task, location, and product.
2. Confirm quantity and, where required, serial number or batch.
3. Place items in the assigned tote or container.
4. Report empty, damaged, or incorrect stock immediately.
5. Close the task only after the physical movement is complete.

Operators must not pick from a location showing a quarantine, blocked, or investigation status. Substitutions are prohibited unless approved by Customer Care and enabled in the order system.

For multi-item orders, totes must remain separated by order or wave. Totes left unattended for more than 30 minutes must be returned to the designated staging area.

4.7 Packing and Quality Check

Packing stations must use the packaging recommendation displayed in Atlas WMS. The packer confirms:

- Correct order and recipient details.
- Product quantity and condition.
- Required accessories, documents, and promotional inserts.
- Carrier service and destination country.
- Packaging suitability and closure.

A second check is required for high-value orders, orders containing more than five SKUs, and any order flagged by the fraud or Customer Care systems. The checker records the verification in Atlas WMS.

Packages must be sealed securely, with no loose labels or exposed product. Customer information must not be visible through transparent packaging. Batteries, liquids, aerosols, and fragile goods require the approved inner protection and external markings.

The packer prints the carrier label only after the parcel weight is recorded. A weight variance above 10% from the system expectation triggers a recheck before dispatch.

4.8 Dispatch and Handover

Completed parcels are scanned into the correct carrier cage or dispatch lane. Carrier manifests are generated in Mercury TMS and reconciled against the physical parcel count before loading.

The Dispatch Supervisor verifies:

- Parcel count by carrier and service.
- Manifest totals and exception parcels.
- Cage or vehicle seal number.
- Collection time and driver identity.

No parcel may be handed to a carrier without a successful dispatch scan. Missed collections, rejected parcels, or manifest differences are logged in the **Delivery Incident Register** within one hour.

Standard dispatch targets are:

- 98.5% of parcels scanned before the carrier collection cut-off.
- 99.7% order-pick accuracy.
- 99.5% parcel-to-manifest reconciliation.
- Same-day escalation for any lost or untraceable parcel.

4.9 Returns and Delivery Exceptions

Customer returns are received against a return authorisation or carrier return reference. The Returns Team classifies each item as:

- Resalable.
- Open-box or rework required.
- Damaged.
- Incomplete.
- Suspected counterfeit or compliance concern.

The classification, photographs, and disposition are recorded in Atlas WMS within two working days. Refund decisions remain with Customer Care and Finance.

Delivery exceptions, including wrong item, missing parcel, damage in transit, or address failure, are recorded against the original order. The Deliveries Support Desk owns carrier enquiries and must issue the first status update within one working day.

Suspected theft, deliberate damage, or repeated carrier loss is escalated to Loss Prevention and the Head of Deliveries.

5. Safety, Security, and Housekeeping

All warehouse staff must complete site induction and role-specific training before working independently. Required PPE is displayed at each site entrance and work area.

Mandatory rules:

- Do not walk beneath raised forks or suspended loads.
- Keep pedestrian routes and fire exits clear.
- Use mechanical aids for loads above the site manual-handling limit of 15 kg.
- Report spills, damaged racking, blocked exits, and unsafe equipment immediately.
- Do not use phones while operating warehouse equipment.
- Challenge or report unidentified persons in restricted areas.

Forklift and powered-equipment operators must hold current site-approved certification. Equipment defects are tagged **OUT OF SERVICE** and reported through the **SafeTrack** incident system.

At shift end, operators clear waste, return scanners to charging points, secure high-value stock, and leave workstations ready for the next shift.

6. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Head of Deliveries:** Owns this manual, service levels, and cross-site compliance.
- **Warehouse Operations Manager:** Implements procedures, approves exceptions, and reviews performance.
- **Inbound Supervisor:** Controls appointments, receiving, discrepancies, and quarantine decisions.
- **Inventory Controller:** Maintains stock accuracy, cycle counts, and adjustment records.
- **Picking and Packing Supervisors:** Manage labour, quality checks, and cut-off performance.
- **Dispatch Supervisor:** Controls carrier handover, manifests, and departure records.
- **Quality Lead:** Decides disposition of damaged, non-compliant, or suspect products.
- **Loss Prevention:** Investigates theft, access breaches, and recurring unexplained loss.
- **All warehouse staff:** Follow approved procedures, scan accurately, and report hazards or exceptions.

7. Performance Reporting and Escalation

The Operations Manager reviews the daily dashboard in **Pulse BI**. Minimum measures include:

- Inbound receipt completion.
- Inventory accuracy and unresolved variances.
- Pick and pack accuracy.
- Orders released before cut-off.
- Parcel dispatch and manifest reconciliation.
- Damage, return, and carrier exception rates.
- Safety incidents and near misses.

Any red KPI for two consecutive working days requires a corrective action plan. A serious safety incident, regulatory concern, suspected fraud, or material customer-data exposure must be escalated immediately to the Head of Deliveries and the relevant Compliance contact.

8. Related Documents and References

- **DEL-TMS-002:** Carrier Booking and Transport Management Standard.
- **DEL-WH-004:** Returns and Product Disposition Procedure.
- **HSE-PRO-014:** Dangerous Goods and Restricted Products.
- **HSE-SAF-001:** Warehouse Health and Safety Standard.
- **INV-CTRL-003:** Inventory Adjustment and Cycle Count Policy.
- **SEC-ACC-006:** Warehouse Access and Visitor Management.
- Atlas WMS work instructions and site layout.
- Mercury TMS carrier service matrix.
- SafeTrack incident reporting guidance.

9. Revision History

- **Version 3.2 — August 2026:** Added parcel weight variance control, revised inventory approval thresholds, and clarified carrier handover requirements.
- **Version 3.1 — February 2026:** Added FEFO requirements for dated products and updated returns classification.
- **Version 3.0 — September 2025:** Consolidated site procedures into the European warehouse standard and introduced Atlas WMS scanning controls.